

Humanities (History & Geography)

Year 7

Cambridge Lower Secondary

Student Manual



Prime Books • Humanities Year 7 • Student Book

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Sources and case studies. All case studies use real places and real examples, redrawn and rewritten for this edition, with sources listed in the Sources & references section.

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INTRODUCTION

How this book works

Geography is the study of the world and our place in it. History is the story of how we got here. Together they help you understand the most important thing there is: the world you actually live in, and how it is changing.

This book teaches geography and history the way real geographers and historians work: by looking closely at evidence. You will study photographs, maps, old documents and real places, and learn to ask the questions that turn looking into understanding. In this first unit you will discover what geography is, meet some of history's great explorers, and learn to ask good geographical questions about the world around you.

What makes this book different

- **Evidence first.** You will work from real sources, not just read about them.
- **Real places.** Case studies use real locations, redrawn and rewritten for

this book, with sources you can check.

- **Command words.** You will learn the six questions that unlock almost any

geographical enquiry.

A note to teachers and parents

This book follows the spirit of an international lower-secondary humanities programme, interpreted afresh for Prime School. Each topic pairs a clear intention with source-based activity and self-assessment, and the "Your turn" questions build towards structured, well-evidenced answers.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

Reading the page

Each topic follows the same rhythm.

PANEL	WHAT IT DOES
In this topic, you will	The goals for the topic.
Getting started	A quick warm-up to wake up what you know.
Source	A photograph, map or document to study closely.
Your turn	Questions and activities for you to do.
Think like a geographer	A task that builds geographical thinking.
Did you know?	A true and surprising fact.
Summary checklist	"I can" statements to check your progress.

How to work

Geographers are nosy. When you look at a source, ask: Who? What? Where? How? Why? When? Those six command words will take you further than any textbook. When a topic asks you to study a place, really look at it: the more you notice, the more you understand.

GETTING SET UP

Before Unit 1

You need only your eyes, your curiosity and a notebook. A map of your local area is a bonus, but not essential.

Your geographer's toolkit

- Curiosity about the world and how it works.
- A notebook for observations, sketches and questions.
- The six command words, which you will learn in this unit.

A quick self-check

- 1 Where in the world are you right now? Be as precise as you can.
- 2 Name one way the place you live has changed in the last ten years.
- 3 What do you think a geographer actually does?

The answers are exactly what Unit 1 will explore. When you can describe what geography is and ask a good geographical question, you are ready to begin.



UNIT 1

1

Geography and you

Learning to read the world around you

© IN THIS UNIT, YOU WILL

- ✓ Discover what geography is and why it matters.
- ✓ Meet some of history's great explorers.
- ✓ Learn the skills in the geographer's toolkit.
- ✓ Ask good questions using the six command words.
- ✓ Study how a real place changes over time.

◆ GETTING STARTED

Where are you right now? Not just "at school" or "at home", but exactly where: which town, which region, which country, which continent, which hemisphere? Write down the most precise answer you can, then compare with a partner. How did you each decide what "where" means?

UNIT 1 • TOPIC 1.1

Welcome to geography

Learn

Geography is the study of the Earth and the people, places and environments on it. Geographers want to know where things are, what they are like, how they work, and how they are changing. It is one of the oldest subjects in the world, because humans have always needed to understand the land they live on.

People have been exploring and mapping the world for centuries. Three great travellers show how curiosity drives geography.

“ SOURCE A • THREE GREAT EXPLORERS

- **Ibn Battuta (1304–1368)**, from Morocco, travelled for nearly thirty years across Africa and Asia, and wrote about the people and places he saw.
- **Captain James Cook (1728–1779)**, from Britain, sailed thousands of miles across the Pacific Ocean, mapping coastlines and islands.
- **Freya Stark (1893–1993)**, from Britain, explored and mapped parts of the Middle East and wrote more than twenty travel books.



Figure 1.1 Explorers mapped the world through curiosity and courage.

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Why do you think these explorers were willing to risk their lives to travel?
- 2 Geographers always want to know where places are. Give the country and continent for each of these:
a. Lisbon b. the Sahara c. the Amazon
a. Mount Everest.
- 3 Look at Source A. What do all three explorers have in common?
- 4 a. Make up three new questions you could ask about a place, using the words Who, What, Where. b. Ask your partner to try to answer them.

∴ THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

Choose a place you know well. Write down three things a geographer might want to know about it, and how you could find each answer.

■ KEYWORDS

- **geography:** the study of the Earth and the people, places and environments on it.
- **explorer:** someone who travels to discover or learn about places.
- **continent:** one of the Earth's large landmasses, such as Europe or Africa.

UNIT 1 • TOPIC 1.2

The geographer's toolkit

Learn

Geographers use a toolkit of skills to study the world. They read and draw **maps**. They study **photographs**, from the ground and from the air. They make careful **observations** of real places, record what they see, and ask questions about it. Above all, they are nosy: they never stop asking why a place is the way it is.

● YOUR TURN

- 1 Match each tool to what it helps a geographer do: a map, a photograph, a notebook. (to record observations / to show where things are / to show what a place looks like)
- 2 Why is asking "why?" such an important geographical skill?
- 3 Which tool would you use to find out how a town has changed? Explain.

■ KEYWORDS

- **map:** a drawing that shows where places and features are.
- **observation:** something you notice by looking carefully.

Asking geographical questions

Learn

The six **command words** are the engine of geographical thinking. Learn them and you can enquire into almost anything.

COMMAND WORD	WHAT IT ASKS	EXAMPLE
Who?	the people involved	Who lives here?
What?	the things happening	What is changing?
Where?	the place	Where is it?
How?	the way it works	How did it happen?
Why?	the reasons	Why is it like this?
When?	the time	When did it change?

• YOUR TURN

- 1 Write one geographical question for each of the six command words, about the town or area where you live.
- 2 Which command word do you think is the most powerful for understanding a place? Give a reason.
- 3 A new road is being built near your school. Write three questions about it, using three different command words.

■ KEYWORDS

- **command words:** the six question words (Who, What, Where, How, Why, When) used to enquire into a place or situation.
- **enquiry:** a careful investigation to find answers.

A changing place

Learn

Change is one of the biggest themes in geography. Places never stay the same: towns grow, coastlines shift, industries rise and fall. Geographers study these changes to understand how places work and what they might become.

Consider the town of **Sintra**, in the hills near Lisbon. For centuries it was a quiet retreat where Portuguese kings built palaces among the cool forests. Today it is one of the most visited places in Portugal, with thousands of visitors arriving each day in summer. The same streets that once served a small mountain town now carry tour buses, cafés and hotels. This change brings money and jobs, but it also brings crowds, traffic and pressure on the old town.



Figure 1.2 Sintra, where a quiet royal retreat became a busy destination.

- YOUR TURN

- 1 a. What was Sintra like in the past? b. What is it like today?
- 2 Give one benefit and one problem that change has brought to Sintra.
- 3 Think of a change happening in your own area, such as a new building or a road being improved. Make up three questions about it, using the command words Who, What and Why.
- 4 Do you think the change in Sintra has been good or bad overall? Give reasons for your view.

- ∴ THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

Imagine Sintra in fifty years. Write two different possible futures for it: one if tourism keeps growing, and one if the town tries to limit visitors. Which do you think is more likely, and why?

UNIT 1 • TOPIC 1.5

How to answer questions

Learn

A good geographical answer does three things. It **answers the question** directly. It **gives evidence** from a source or an example. And it **explains** the reason, using because, so or this means. When you see a question, first spot the command word, then decide what the question is really asking.

- YOUR TURN

- 1 Read this question: "Why do many tourists visit Sintra?" a. What is the command word? b. Write a one-sentence answer that includes evidence.
- 2 Improve this weak answer to "How has Sintra changed?": "It is different now." Rewrite it to answer the question, give evidence and explain.
- 3 Write your own three-sentence answer to: "How is your local area changing?" Use a command word, evidence and an explanation.

SUMMARY CHECKLIST

- ✓ I can describe what geography is and why it matters.
- ✓ I can name some of history's great explorers and what they did.
- ✓ I can use the six command words to ask geographical questions.
- ✓ I can describe how a real place changes over time.
- ✓ I can structure a clear geographical answer with evidence.

UNIT 1 • FINAL PROJECT

Investigate your place

★ FINAL PROJECT

Investigate your place

Become a geographer. Choose a place you know, such as your street, your neighbourhood or your town, and carry out a small geographical enquiry into how it is changing. Present your findings as a one-page report.

What to hand in

- A clear geographical question about your place, using a command word.
- Your observations: what you noticed, with a sketch map or description.
- A short answer to your question, with evidence and explanation.
- One prediction about how your place might change in future.

How it will be judged

Criterion	Weight	--- ---	Quality of the geographical question	30%	Care and detail of observations	30%	
Evidence and explanation in the answer	30%	Clarity of presentation	10%				

UNIT 1 • CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

- 1 What is geography?
- 2 Name one explorer from Source A and say what they did.
- 3 What are the six command words?
- 4 Give one way Sintra has changed over time.
- 5 a. What does a geographer use a map for? b. What does a notebook record?
- 6 Write one question about a place using "Why?", and one using "Where?".
- 7 What three things does a good geographical answer include?

UNIT 1 • EVALUATION

Be honest. Colour the circle that matches how you feel about each outcome: green means confident, amber means nearly there, red means needs more work.

I CAN ...	GREEN	AMBER	RED
describe what geography is	☐	☐	☐
name great explorers and what they did	☐	☐	☐
use the six command words	☐	☐	☐
describe how a real place changes	☐	☐	☐
structure a clear geographical answer	☐	☐	☐

UNIT 1 • WHAT CAN YOU DO?

✓ WHAT CAN YOU DO?

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Describe what geography is and why it matters. | ☐ Describe how a real place changes over time. |
| ☐ Name some of history's great explorers. | ☐ Structure a geographical answer with evidence. |
| ☐ Use the six command words to ask questions. | |

■ UNIT 1 ROUND-UP

geography • explorer • continent • map • observation • command words • enquiry • evidence

GLOSSARY

Unit 1

command words: the six question words (Who, What, Where, How, Why, When) used to enquire into a place or situation.

continent: one of the Earth's large landmasses, such as Europe or Africa.

enquiry: a careful investigation to find answers.

evidence: information from a source that supports an answer.

explorer: someone who travels to discover or learn about places.

geography: the study of the Earth and the people, places and environments on it.

map: a drawing that shows where places and features are.

observation: something you notice by looking carefully.

SOURCES & REFERENCES

Where everything came from

The case study and sources in this unit use real places and real people. Links were live as of July 2026.

S UNIT 1 • GEOGRAPHY AND YOU

- 1 **Sintra.** The town used for the changing-place case study in Topic 1.4. A real town in the hills near Lisbon, known for its royal palaces and now a major visitor destination. <<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sintra>>
- 2 **Ibn Battuta.** The Moroccan explorer (1304–1368) who travelled across Africa and Asia for nearly thirty years. <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ibn_Battuta>
- 3 **James Cook.** The British explorer (1728–1779) who mapped coastlines across the Pacific Ocean. <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/James_Cook>
- 4 **Freya Stark.** The British explorer and travel writer (1893–1993) who mapped parts of the Middle East. <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Freya_Stark>

Learn to read the world.

This Year 7 Student Book teaches geography and history the way real geographers and historians work: by looking closely at evidence. You will meet great explorers, learn the six questions that unlock any place, and study how a real Portuguese town is changing.

Written for Prime School pupils, in clear British English, with real places and real sources you can check.

GEOGRAPHY

HISTORY

EVIDENCE

EXPLORERS

CHANGE